

D A T A S A I L

Weekly Meeting

March 25, 2026



AI & DS News



Intro to Kaggle

AI & DATA SCIENCE

NEWS ROUNDUP • March 2026

01

What's been happening in the world of AI and data science?

AI Drives a Mars Rover — No Human Required

456

meters
driven on Mars

NASA's Perseverance rover completed the first AI-planned drives on another planet in December 2025, with results announced in early 2026.

How it worked:

Claude (Anthropic's AI) used vision-language models to analyze orbital imagery, identify hazards like boulder fields and sand ripples, and generate a safe waypoint path.

 **Why it matters for us:** This is vision-language AI being applied to real-world autonomous decision making, the same category of models behind tools we use daily. It also shows AI as a 'multiplier' at NASA, which faces budget and staffing cuts.

The AI & Data Science Job Market in 2026

What 700+ job postings reveal:

- GenAI skills now appear in 1 in 3 DS job postings
- Top roles: ML Engineer, AI Researcher, Data Engineer
- Companies adopting AI hire 20%+ more than non-adopters (Harvard study)
- CDO / Chief Data Officer role at an all-time high (70% call it successful)

70%

of large orgs say CDO role is established & successful

20%+

more hiring at AI-adopting companies

 **For us:** GenAI proficiency is now expected, not a bonus. Data engineering and MLOps skills alongside classic ML are increasingly what employers want. Building a Kaggle portfolio helps!

INTRO TO

Kaggle

02

What it is, why it matters, and how we'll use it

What is Kaggle?

Datasets

Thousands of free, real-world datasets on everything from healthcare to sports to finance. Perfect for side projects or practice.

Notebooks

A hosted Jupyter-like environment with free GPU/TPU access. You can code right in the browser — no setup needed.

Competitions

Companies (Google, Meta, Kaggle itself) post real ML problems with cash prizes. You build a model and submit predictions.

Courses

Free micro-courses in Python, ML, deep learning, feature engineering, etc. Great for filling gaps.

Anatomy of a Competition

1

Problem

Kaggle posts a task: "predict house prices" or "classify images".

2

Data

You download train.csv (labeled) and test.csv (no labels) and explore.

3

Model

Build & train your ML model. Tune hyperparameters to improve accuracy.

4

Submit

Upload a predictions file. The leaderboard updates your public score instantly.

5

Iterate

Analyze errors, try new features or models, resubmit. Repeat until deadline.

💡 Each competition comes with a discussion forum and notebooks shared by other participants, a huge learning resource!

The Kaggle Rank System

 **Novice**

Just signed up. Explore datasets and run notebooks.

 **Contributor**

Complete a few tasks: run a notebook, make a submission, vote on a discussion.

 **Expert**

Win a bronze medal in competitions or datasets. Shows real ML chops.

 **Master**

Multiple gold/silver medals. Very strong competitors.

 **Grandmaster**

Top 0.1% globally. Multiple competition golds.

Data SAIL × Kaggle

THIS WEEK

Today

Intro to Kaggle: what it is, how competitions work, create your account!

NEXT WEEK

Live Demo

Walk through a starter competition together
Titanic Survival Prediction (the 'Hello World' of Kaggle).

WEEK 3

Compete!

Pick a beginner-friendly competition. Build and submit as a team. Share notebooks and strategies.